

Chapter 102 - Sunrise

Around seven in the evening, Yan Lin and Feng Yue went for a walk in a park within their villa area.

The two were like any ordinary couple, walking side by side on the park's paths against the comfortable evening breeze.

Like them, there were many children in the villa area, either brought out by parents and family members or by nannies and aunts, laughing and chasing each other, enjoying the last light of the day.

The park in the villa area was quite large, with trees, lawns, and benches for resting visible everywhere. The good green environment was also a selling point of this villa area, and it seemed they had done quite well.

The two wandered aimlessly around the park, round after round, until the park's streetlights came on and the crowds dispersed. Only then did Yan Lin find a suitable bench close to a streetlight to sit down.

The two sat quietly on the bench like this, neither speaking first, just quietly listening to the insect chirping from the low bushes in the park.

Time passed minute by minute, and the two didn't know how long they had been sitting there. Suddenly a cool breeze blew past, and Feng Yue instinctively shivered, then quickly returned to normal.

Yan Lin, sitting beside her, didn't miss this subtle movement. She turned her head and asked in a low voice, "Are you a little cold?"

Feng Yue nodded, then explained, "But it's nothing."

Yan Lin looked at the time and said, "It's getting late. Although the temperature hasn't been low these past few days, it still gets cold at night. Shall we go back? I'll wake you up early tomorrow morning and we can come out to watch again."

Feng Yue looked up at the dark sky above, which only had scattered stars, far inferior to what she had seen in the planetarium last time.

"No need." She shook her head and said, "I don't want to die stuffily confined in a room. Even if I must die, I want to smell the morning dew, see the rising sun, and hear the crisp bird songs - only then will I have no regrets. After all, in the days to come, I'll have plenty of time to be trapped in one place, sleeping eternally."

Hearing this, Yan Lin fell quiet. However, before completely falling silent, she still took off the coat she was wearing and draped it over Feng Yue.

Feng Yue looked down at the coat on her shoulders, which still carried that familiar orange blossom scent. She didn't refuse Yan Lin's kindness, curved her eyebrows slightly, and thanked her, "Thank you."

Yan Lin didn't speak, just tentatively took hold of Feng Yue's hand that was resting on her lap. Seeing that Feng Yue didn't resist, she held the hand tightly.

However, waiting for sunlight is always long and tedious.

Despite this, the two sitting quietly on the bench showed no signs of impatience or drowsiness.

They had too many things hidden in their hearts. These things weighed on them, making it almost hard for them to breathe. Only when lost in thought could they get a moment's respite.

The two sat quietly on the park bench all night like this, until dawn broke on the horizon and a warm yellow-orange light broke through the sky, passing through clouds to reflect in their eyes.

May 4th, 6:20 AM, the orange light belonging to the sun emerged from the east.

This wasn't Feng Yue's first time seeing a sunrise, but she felt that in her twenty-something years of life, no sunrise could compare to this moment.

Feng Yue seemed to visibly come alive. Yan Lin turned her head to look at her and suddenly felt it was very unreal.

Feng Yue's skin was already fair, and now with sunlight falling entirely on her face, she was illuminated almost like a crystal-clear porcelain doll, even her eyebrows and eyelashes taking on a golden tinge.

As if she might shatter in the next second.

Yan Lin turned her head back, not daring to look anymore, instead raising her eyes to gaze at that streak of dawn on the horizon. But whether it was because the sunlight was too dazzling, tears welled up in her eyes. If she blinked even once, those teardrops would all fall to the ground.

In the end, Yan Lin still held back her tears, because Feng Yue leaned slightly toward her, resting her head on her shoulder.

"Ah Lin, I'm a little tired."

Yan Lin moved her stiff arm, carefully wrapping it around Feng Yue's shoulder from behind and gently patting her. Not having spoken for a long time made her voice somewhat hoarse when she finally spoke. She cleared her throat lightly and said, "Sleep then."

Feng Yue gently closed her eyes, falling asleep to the sound of Yan Lin's vigorous heartbeat.

Feng Yue's breathing became steady, but Yan Lin stared fixedly at the watch on her wrist without looking away.

Second after second, minute after minute, until they were about to cross that moment that pained her so much.

Two more minutes! Ah Yue definitely won't die!

Yan Lin was so excited her face flushed red, though she didn't move the body that Feng Yue was leaning against at all.

Feng Yue felt that sensation again - that very familiar feeling of helplessness rising from the bottom of her heart. Just when she thought she would die in her sleep, a clarity came from her brain, and her body gained an indescribable strength.

A final surge of energy¹.

Feng Yue struggled to open her eyes and saw Yan Lin's excellent jawline and that familiar profile.

"Ah Lin."

Fifty seconds.

Hearing her voice, Yan Lin no longer stared fixedly at the time on her watch, but looked down at Feng Yue with a face full of joy, "Ah Yue! You're awake?!"

"Then you'll definitely be fine! There's less than a minute left before that time passes!" She even gestured to the watch on her wrist while speaking to Feng Yue.

Feng Yue reached out and pressed down the hand wearing the watch, "Ah Lin, I prepared a gift for you. It's on the desk in my room."

Twenty seconds.

Yan Lin was stunned upon hearing this, then immediately said after recovering, "Then we'll go get it later. I want to see my gift."

Yan Lin looked at those calm eyes gazing at her, and an inexplicable sense of panic involuntarily rose in her heart.

"Take care of them." The strength that had suddenly surged in Feng Yue's body receded like a tide. Her hand pressing on Yan Lin's wrist began to tremble. She struggled to lift it, wanting to touch something, but it ultimately fell back onto her body.

"Take care of yourself..." Two extremely light words were scattered and extinguished by the wind in the morning air.

Feng Yue smelled the morning dew and the familiar orange blossoms, saw the rising sun and the familiar face, heard the crisp bird songs and the vigorous heartbeat.

May 4th, 9:47 AM.

Yan Lin looked at the precise time on her watch, her whole body seeming to freeze in place, motionless, with only teardrops falling from her eyes like broken strings.

This time, she finally saw Feng Yue's last moments, but also became the only one to do so.

Yan Lin remained frozen there until the crisp sounds of beads falling to the ground pulled her consciousness back.

She looked at the golden nanmu prayer beads falling one by one from the broken bracelet, finally all falling into the lawn behind them.

The bracelet broke?

Yan Lin's eyes stared unblinkingly at those beads on the ground. If she wasn't mistaken, those beads were covered with cracks - at least one crack on each bead.

Yan Lin suddenly remembered something. What had her mother said at the time?

"Ah Lin, I had this bracelet blessed at Jintai Temple². It can ward off disasters. Remember to have Xiao Yue wear it always."

An incredible thought flashed through Yan Lin's mind. She quickly placed her finger under Feng Yue's nose - she couldn't feel a trace of breath.

Not believing it, Yan Lin touched the artery at Feng Yue's neck, and this time finally felt some movement.

Although the pulse was slow, there was still hope for rescue!

Then, with a face full of wild joy, she took out her phone and called Wei Yu Ran, then contacted the villa area's medical team.

Feng Yue's consciousness fell into darkness, just like in her previous life, drifting for who knows how long, not knowing where she was going.

Blue light appeared in the distance. Like the experience before, Feng Yue was forcibly sucked by an extremely strong suction into that area shrouded in blue light.

When Feng Yue opened her eyes again, what she saw wasn't the light blue brightness like before, but flashing red lights and piercing alarm sounds.

In the center of the room still sat that book, but just like when she had fainted and come here before, there wasn't a single word on it.

Feng Yue took the book in her hands, wanting to investigate, but discovered nothing.

How did she come here again? Shouldn't she have died directly this time? And this book - why were there no words on it anymore?

Just as Feng Yue was puzzled, a line of text suddenly flashed on the wall flashing with red light in front of her.

【Warning! Small world protagonist consciousness awakened, causing world consciousness awakening, small world breaking free from control countdown...】

【Space self-destruction program activated, countdown...】

【Space detected intruder, intruder consciousness elimination program activated, countdown...】

These few short lines made Feng Yue's blood run cold. When she saw the words "intruder," an inexplicable fear rose in her heart. If she guessed correctly, this intruder must be her.

Feng Yue didn't want her consciousness erased, but she couldn't find any way to resist. She could only watch helplessly as the countdown got closer and closer, less and less.

Three...

Two...

Just in that last second, a violent electric current swept through Feng Yue's entire body, forcibly pulling her out of this red-light flashing place.

Just before she left, she saw the last line of text left on that wall.

【Intruder disappeared, space self-destruction program activated.】

Feng Yue looked at this text and fell once again into deep, thick darkness.

However, this time she seemed to hear some different sounds.

"Adjust asynchronous biphasic wave 200 joules."

"Charging complete, defibrillation, clear!"

Yan Lin waited outside the emergency room, Feng Yue's coat draped over her arm and Feng Yue's phone in her hand.

And just moments ago, Yan Lin had watched with her own eyes as the bright yellow triangular talisman paper tucked behind Feng Yue's transparent phone case turned to ash in the blink of an eye.

This talisman was what she had originally given to Feng Yue along with the golden nanmu bracelet.

Footnotes:

¹ "Final surge of energy" (回光返照) - A Chinese idiom literally meaning "return of light and reflection," referring to the brief revival of energy or consciousness that sometimes occurs just before death.

² "Jintai Temple" (金台寺) - A Buddhist temple mentioned earlier in the story where the protective items were blessed.